Replication of 'An Adaptive Perspective on Visual Working Memory Distortions' by Chunharas, Rademaker, Brady, and Serences (2022, Journal of Experimental Psychology)

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Introduction

This experiment will be a replication of Chunharas & Brady, 2022[1]. The original focus of the paper was to elucidate properties of visual working memory. The goal of experiment 1 was to demonstrate repulsion as a functional memory distortion, when remembering a small set of

very similar, yet distinguishable items (colors). Repulsion serves to make the representations of each color more distinct from one another while held in visual working memory. The first experiment in Chunharas, 2022 consisted of a two-alternative forced choice task (2-AFC) using a color wheel. Experiment 1 yielded very strong evidence for repulsion bias as a feature visual working memory. Their results demonstrated participants were "better at rejecting a foil color that was distorted toward the non-target memory item than rejecting a foil color that was distorted away from the non-target memory item" (Chunharas, 2022).

For this replication, the experiment will consist of the same 2-AFC color wheel VWM task from Experiment 1 of Chunharas, 2022, able to be conducted online through the SONA platform. The task involves a continuous color wheel, where there will be 2 color samples displayed from the wheel: one "correct" color and one non-target color, 45^{o} apart in color space from each other. The participant will then be asked to choose the correct target from two colors, one of which will be a foil either 6^{o} towards the non-target or 6^{o} away from the non-target (in relation to the correct color). The experiment was a within-subjects design where each condition was equally balanced, 60 trials of each type. I will have to re-code it in Javascript, HTML, and CSS, since the original experiment used MATLAB and Psychophysics toolbox. Thankfully, all of the paper's code was registered via OSF, including the original code for the task, participant data, and analysis code. Following data collection, data analysis will consist of a paired t-tests on accuracy. The original results showed toward vs. away gave $t(44)=3.98$, $p<.001$, toward vs. chance gave $t(44)=3.73$, $p=.006$, and away vs. chance gave $t(44)=-1.76$, $p=.08$.

OSF Link: https://osf.io/qp6xk/files/osfstorage?view_only=0559769c587c4c8294288451e8af239e

Replication Repository: https://github.com/jamesrashby21/chunharas2022

Replication Paper: https://dx.doi.org/10.1037/xlm0001014

Methods

Replication task will be coded in Javascript, HTML, and CSS, adapted to the SONA online platform. With the help of one of the researchers, Dr. Tim Brady, I have obtained newly made JSPsych plugins developed after the original experiment that should make coding the 2-AFC color wheel task much easier. Data analysis and visualization will be done in R, and documented with Quarto.

Power Analysis

Effect size not displayed in the original paper, but can be extrapolated from data and figures later. Power analysis needed to confirm viability of sample size in order to achieve 80%, 90%, 95% power to detect the original effect size.

Planned Sample

The sample will consist of UC San Diego undergraduates, recruited via the SONA platform and compensated with class credit for their participation. The anticipated sample will be pre-screened to ensure normal or corrected-to-normal vision without any color-blindness. The estimated size of the sample will be 50 people, which is only slightly more than the original population. The larger sample population is due to extraneous noise that can sometimes occur during online experiments among a busy student population.

Materials

All materials consist of the code needed to recreate the task, and access to the online SONA platform.

Procedure

The task was coded in HTML, CSS, and Javascript, using JSPsych plugins made by the UCSD Vision and Memory lab. The task display will consist of a 500x500 pixel white background with a 1 pixel wide, with a fixation cross in the center, surrounded by 12 small circular placeholders each centered at a distance of 120 pixels. Each placeholder should have a radius of 20 pixels, and will be 62 pixels apart when measuring center-to-center. There will be 6 placeholders on the left side of the screen, and 6 on the right. There are also two empty placeholders on the left and right of the cross, 35 pixels from fixation. Finally, the location probe on screen is a small equilateral black triangle, 20 pixels wide and 20 pixels tall.

The task consisted of showing participants two colors on the color wheel, one "correct" color, and one non-target color, which will always be 45^{o} away in color space from the correct color. There were also 2 empty placeholders between each of the two memory items. Following a 750ms delay, a location cue appears on screen identifying the correct color. This was followed by the two placeholders next to the fixation cross presenting two response options. One response was always the correct color, while the other was always a foil, which differed either by 6^{o} toward the non-target color, or 6^{o} away totaling 120 trials (60 trials each, balanced across conditions). The position of the correct color on either the left or right of the fixation cross was randomized. The participants were asked to select one of the two color choices on screen on either the left (Z key) or on the right (M key), before advancing.

Analysis Plan

Data analysis will consist of simply running a paired samples t-test comparing accuracy between the two foil conditions in the 2-AFC task.

I also plan to visualize the data myself, and see if I can plot new figures if reaction time was recorded.

```
setwd("~/yourWorkingDirectory/.../data_codes/R") # <- please change this to your own path

#### EXP1 ####
dat = 'EXP1_subj_fdist_fdirec_val.csv'
datcsv = read.csv(dat, header = FALSE)
colnames(datcsv) = c('subj','fdist','fdirec','val')

datcsv$subj = as.factor(datcsv$subj)
datcsv$fdirec = as.factor(datcsv$fdirec)

# t-test
t.test(datcsv[datcsv$fdirec==-1,'val']-datcsv[datcsv$fdirec==1,'val'])
```

Differences from Original Study

There will be slight variations to this sample, in that the original sample consisted of individuals recruited from Amazon Mechanical Turk. We will differ in that this will likely be a younger, WEIRD-er, university student sample. Since we are talking about fundamental processing systems that constitute visual memory, I do not expect any differences in the results or conclusions, but I will need to ensure proper pre-screening to rule out color-blind participants.

Methods Addendum (Post Data Collection)

You can comment this section out prior to final report with data collection.

Actual Sample

Sample size, demographics, data exclusions based on rules spelled out in analysis plan

Differences from pre-data collection methods plan

Any differences from what was described as the original plan, or "none".

Results

Data preparation

Data preparation following the analysis plan.

Confirmatory analysis

The analyses as specified in the analysis plan.

Side-by-side graph with original graph is ideal here

Exploratory analyses

Any follow-up analyses desired (not required).

Discussion

Summary of Replication Attempt

Open the discussion section with a paragraph summarizing the primary result from the confirmatory analysis and the assessment of whether it replicated, partially replicated, or failed to replicate the original result.

Commentary

Add open-ended commentary (if any) reflecting (a) insights from follow-up exploratory analysis, (b) assessment of the meaning of the replication (or not) - e.g., for a failure to replicate, are the differences between original and present study ones that definitely, plausibly, or are unlikely to have been moderators of the result, and (c) discussion of any objections or challenges raised by the current and original authors about the replication attempt. None of these need to be long.